

82 Non-defining relative clauses

Like defining relative clauses, non-defining relative clauses add extra information about something. However, this simply gives extra detail, rather than changing the sentence's meaning.

See also:

Quantity 75

Defining relative clauses 81

82.1 NON-DEFINING RELATIVE CLAUSES

In non-defining relative clauses, also known as non-restrictive relative clauses, "who" is used to refer to people. "Whom" can be used if the person is the object of the relative clause, but this is very formal.

MAIN CLAUSE NON-DEFINING RELATIVE CLAUSE

We spoke to Linda, **who had recently been mugged**.

"Who" refers to a person.



"Which" is used to refer to anything that is not a person. "That" is sometimes used instead of "which," but this is often considered wrong in non-defining relative clauses.

MAIN CLAUSE NON-DEFINING RELATIVE CLAUSE RETURN TO MAIN CLAUSE

Her necklace, **which she'd just bought**, was stolen.

"Which" refers to a thing.



FURTHER EXAMPLES

Jay, **who I used to live with**, came to stay with us for a few days.



The suspect, **whom we had been following**, was arrested.



"Whom" is only used in very formal situations.

All the burglars were arrested, **which was a great relief**.



Our new house, **which is by the beach**, is beautiful.



The relative pronoun can refer to the entire previous clause.